

Strengths-Based Coaching Guide

Identifying genuine strengths, applying them deliberately in your current role, recognizing their overuse risks, and building a development plan that leverages what already works rather than only fixing what doesn't.

Why Strengths-Based, Not Just Deficit-Based

Most development planning starts by asking what's wrong and working backward to a fix. This guide starts from the opposite direction deliberately: identifying what already produces your best work, then applying more of it — not instead of addressing genuine gaps, but alongside it. Both matter; this guide focuses on the half that's usually neglected.

1. Strengths Identification Framework

A genuine strength is different from a skill you happen to be competent at. The distinguishing test is energy: a real strength leaves you energized after using it, regardless of how effortful the task looked from outside. A skill you're merely competent at, by contrast, is usually draining even when you do it well.

Four Ways to Identify a Genuine Strength

Method	How It Works
The Energy Test	After doing something, notice whether you feel energized or drained — independent of how well it went. Energized, regardless of outcome, is the signal
Peak Performance Recall	Recall 2-3 specific moments of your genuinely best work. Look for the pattern that repeats across them, not what was unique to each
The Feedback Pattern	What do people consistently come to you for, across different relationships and contexts — not just what you're told once
Flow Noticing	What tasks make you lose track of time entirely? Sustained, effortless focus is a strong strength signal

Identification Worksheet

List 3-5 candidate strengths, then check which identification methods above actually support each one. A strength confirmed by multiple methods is more reliable than one identified by only one.

Candidate Strength	Energy?	Peak Moments?	Feedback Pattern?	Flow?
Example: Simplifying complex problems for others	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

2. Role Application Guide

Knowing a strength exists doesn't automatically mean it's being used deliberately in your current role. Many strengths sit underused simply because no one, including the person themselves, has explicitly connected them to a specific responsibility.

Three Ways to Apply a Strength More Deliberately

- Reshape an existing responsibility to use it more — the task doesn't need to change, just how you approach it
- Take on a specific, bounded piece of work that draws on it directly, even if it's not formally part of your role yet
- Partner deliberately with someone whose strengths cover what yours doesn't, rather than trying to develop competence in an area that will likely never be a genuine strength

Application Worksheet

Strength	Current Application	Underused Opportunity	Specific Action
Example: Simplifying complex problems	Occasionally used in ad hoc explanations	Rarely used deliberately in formal presentations to leadership	Volunteer to lead the next executive briefing, structuring it around this strength explicitly

3. Over-Use Risk Awareness

Every genuine strength has a shadow side — the same pattern, applied without awareness or in the wrong context, becomes a liability. This is not a reason to use a strength less; it's a reason to use it with more self-awareness.

Common Strength-to-Overuse Patterns

Strength Pattern	Overuse Risk	Balancing Behavior
Decisiveness	Moving to a decision before genuinely hearing dissenting views; steamrolling quieter voices	Deliberately ask "what am I missing?" before finalizing, especially under time pressure
Empathy	Difficulty holding people accountable, or absorbing others' emotional burden as your own	Separate caring about someone from removing consequences for their actual performance
Strategic Thinking	Dismissing simpler, more immediate solutions in favor of a more elegant long-term one; analysis paralysis	Ask whether the situation actually calls for a strategic answer, or just needs a fast, adequate one
Attention to Detail	Missing the bigger picture; frustrating collaborators who move faster and looser	Explicitly ask "does this level of precision matter here?" before applying it by default
Drive for Results	Burning out yourself or the team; treating relationships as instrumental to output	Check in on team wellbeing as a genuine priority, not just a means to sustaining output

Reflection

For each strength you identified in Section 1: what does this look like when it's overused, specifically for you?
Has anyone ever given you feedback that, in hindsight, was actually about a strength taken too far rather than a genuine weakness?

4. Development Planning Prompts

Use the reflection below to build a development plan that leverages your genuine strengths deliberately, while staying aware of their overuse risk — rather than a plan built entirely around fixing weaknesses.

Reflection Questions

- Which strength, if applied more deliberately, would have the biggest impact on your current role?
- What's specifically stopping you from applying it more — lack of opportunity, lack of confidence, or simply not having named it explicitly before now?
- Which overuse risk from Section 3 is most relevant to you, and what's one concrete way you'll stay aware of it?
- Who can give you honest feedback on both your strength application and its overuse risk, on an ongoing basis?

Development Plan

Strength to Leverage More	Specific Application	Overuse Risk to Watch	Check-in Plan
Example: Simplifying complex problems	Lead structuring of the quarterly executive briefing	Oversimplifying in a way that loses important nuance for technical stakeholders	Ask a technical peer to review for lost nuance before each briefing

Revisit this plan every 2-3 months — strengths application tends to fade back to old habits without a deliberate check-in, even when the initial insight felt clear.